before the latter paid his first visit to that country, Patel opined that the US actually held the key to the international situation. He felt that without American cooperation, it would be difficult for India to industrialize significantly. Keeping that in mind, he made out a more India-centric case for collaboration than Nehru, whose overall assessment was more coloured by the need to create a non-aligned front. Two years later, in one of his last public appearances, Patel pointedly remarked that many people believed that India should not take American help because it would lose prestige and be perceived as joining a bloc. He felt that India was quite capable of realizing its own interest and position. In that sense, the origins of an 'India First' outlook go back many decades, though it clearly took a nationalist ideology to bring it back to life now.

The other issue pertains to the hesitation in recognizing Israel and establishing full diplomatic relations. Patel was clearly uncomfortable with the vote-bank pressures on Nehru and believed that this should not be given a determining say over the making of national policy. As with some other foreign policy issues, his thinking did not prevail, and it was not until PM Modi's 2017 visit to Israel that this issue was finally put to rest.

The quest for a more perfect union is one that is pursued by all diverse societies and federal polities. Indeed, if there is one area in which Patel left an indelible imprint, it is in national integration. As a civilization that values unity in diversity, it is vital that we nurture the bonds that bind us together. Our journey in the last 75 years has not been without its obstacles. If we have successfully surmounted them, it is, in large part, due to a national determination that emanates from the Sardar's legacy.

But there are issues left over from his era in which neglect had been rationalized to great measure over the years. Catering to vested interests or ignoring ground realities cannot serve us well. World politics is extremely competitive and others are constantly looking for weaknesses within. Our deep underlying pluralism that harmonizes so much diversity is our civilizational strength, not just a contemporary creation. We know this instinctively, though some parts of the world may struggle to understand.

An India that is true to its roots will always be strong and resilient. Our thinking is best driven by self-belief and national awareness. Sardar Patel presciently cautioned us in 1948 against submitting our positions to the interests and judgement of others. That holds true as much now as it did then.